Simeon Datumanong

Simeon Ampatuan Datumanong (June 17, 1935 – February 28, 2017) was a Maguindanaon lawyer, provincial executive, regional administrator, legislator, and cabinet secretary whose public career spanned more than five decades of Philippine history.

Born in Maganoy — now called Shariff Aguak — in the undivided province of Cotabato, he rose from provincial board member to Secretary of Justice, serving at every tier of Philippine governance along the way: local, regional, legislative, and executive.

He is best remembered as the first administrator to organize the provincial government of Maguindanao after its creation under Presidential Decree 341 in 1973, a member of the Philippine government's negotiating panel for the landmark 1976 Tripoli Agreement, a five-term congressman representing Maguindanao's Second District, and twice Deputy Speaker of the House of Representatives.

His people knew him simply as **Bapa Sim** — an affectionate term of elder-familial respect that captured both his stature and his style of leadership.

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EARLY LIFE AND EDUCATION

Simeon Ampatuan Datumanong was born on June 17, 1935, in Maganoy — the town now known as Shariff Aguak — in what was then the single, undivided province of Cotabato.

He came from a noble Maguindanaon clan whose social standing had long been tied to both spiritual authority and political leadership in the region. The surname "Datumanong" is itself a marker of

Simeon Ampatuan Datumanong

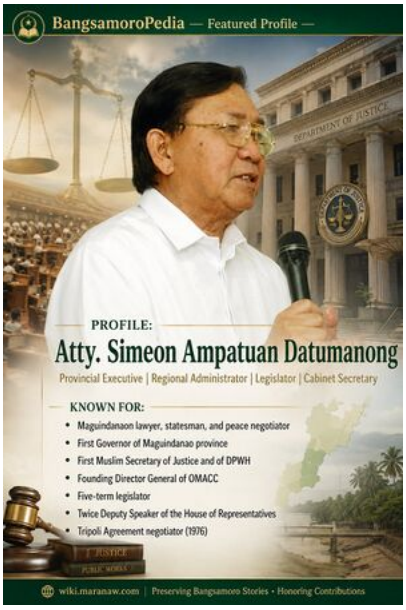


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Personal Information

Born: June 17, 1935
Maganoy (now Shariff Aguak), Cotabato

Died: February 28, 2017 (aged 81)
Philippine Heart Center, Quezon City

Ethnicity: Maguindanaon

Religion: Islam

Family

Father: Datu Dundoy Bapa-i Datumanong Giamad
Mother: Bai Salama Ampatuan

lineage: "datu" is the traditional Maguindanaon title for chieftain or nobility. His father was Datu Dundoy Bapa-i Datumanong Giamad; his mother, Bai Salama Ampatuan, was a daughter of Datu Alon Ampatuan, the older brother of Sharif Aguak — a lineage that explains the middle name "Ampatuan" that Simeon carried throughout his life.

His early schooling was marked by consistent academic distinction. He completed elementary school at Cotabato Central School in 1951 as class valedictorian, and then went on to Cotabato High School, where he graduated in 1955 as first honorable mention.

These were no small achievements in mid-century Cotabato, where formal education was still a scarce commodity in Muslim communities that had long been pushed to the margins of the Philippine state's modernizing ambitions.

What set him on a different path from many of his peers was his decision to pursue law at the University of the Philippines College of Law — then, as now, the country's most prestigious law school. He completed his Bachelor of Laws and passed the Philippine Bar Examinations in 1959.

The significance of this bears emphasis: a young Muslim man from Cotabato entering UP's law program, completing it, and joining the Philippine bar, all during a period when Muslim Mindanao was still widely treated as a peripheral and suspect frontier of the republic.

After admission to the bar, he returned to Cotabato and practiced law briefly before his trajectory was, almost inevitably, redirected toward public life. Those who worked with him in those early years described him as meticulous, measured, and constitutionally inclined — qualities that would define every role he took on afterward.

He later married Hadja Sittie Mariam Sigrid de Guzman Datumanong, with whom he had four children: Borgiva Tasmi, Merinisa Anisalam, Soraya Julie, and Rahma Anna Liza, and eventually thirteen grandchildren.

ENTRY INTO PROVINCIAL POLITICS

Datumanong's formal entry into politics came in 1962 when he was elected as a provincial board member of Cotabato — the bottom rung of provincial governance, but a platform from which he quickly demonstrated capacity.

In 1966, he was elected Vice-Governor of Cotabato. He became Governor the following year under circumstances worth noting precisely: in the November 1966 local elections, Congressman Salipada K. Pendatun won the governorship of Cotabato, but chose

(daughter of Datu Alon Ampatuan, older brother of Sharif Aguak) *(family-sourced)*

Spouse: Hadja Sittie Mariam Sigrid de Guzman Datumanong

Children: Borgiva Tasmi, Merinisa Anisalam, Soraya Julie, Rahma Anna Liza

Grandchildren: 13

Education

Cotabato Central School (valedictorian, 1951)
Cotabato High School (first honorable mention, 1955)
University of the Philippines College of Law (LLB, 1959)
Philippine Bar (admitted, 1959)

Career in Public Office

Provincial Board Member, Cotabato (1962–1966)
Vice-Governor, Cotabato (1966–1967)
Governor, Cotabato (1967–1971)
First Provincial Administrator/Governor, Maguindanao (1973–1975) *(organized the new province under PD 341)*
Regional Commissioner, Region XII (1975–1979)
Co-Chairperson, Provisional Government, Southern Philippines (1977)
Regional Assemblyman, Autonomous Regional Government of Western Mindanao (1979–1984)
Chairperson, Lupong Tagapagpaganap ng Pook (LTP), Autonomous Region XII (1980–1984)
Representative, Batasang Pambansa, Maguindanao (1984–1986)
Director General, Office on Muslim Affairs and Cultural Communities (OMACC) (1984–1986)
Member, Board of Directors, Philippine Amanah Bank (1985–1986)
Member, Board of Directors, United Coconut Planters Bank (1986–1992)
Representative, House of Representatives, Maguindanao 2nd District (1992–2001)
Deputy Speaker, House of Representatives (1995–1998)
Secretary, Department of Public Works and Highways (2001–2003)
Secretary, Department of Justice (2003)
Representative, House of Representatives, Maguindanao 2nd

to return to Congress without taking his oath of office as Governor. With the governorship vacant, Datumanong, as Vice-Governor, ascended to the position in 1967 — a distinction the family has been careful to preserve: he did not win the governorship by direct election, but assumed it through constitutional succession. He held the position until 1971.

Cotabato in the late 1960s was, in every sense, a pressure cooker. The province was ethnically, religiously, and politically volatile. Land disputes between Christian settlers and the indigenous Muslim and lumad populations had been simmering for years — the result of settlement policies enacted through national law long before Datumanong's time, among them the Osmena Colony Act of 1912, the Quirino-Recto Colonization Act of 1936, and the vigorous resettlement programs of the Magsaysay administration. These were decisions made by presidents and acts of Congress, not by local executives. But their consequences fell squarely on the communities Datumanong governed. The armed Moro resistance that would eventually crystallize into the Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF) was still taking shape underground, but its precursors — grievances over land dispossession, political marginalization, and cultural degradation — were visible to any governor willing to look clearly at his constituents.

Datumanong governed Cotabato during this period as a pragmatic administrator rather than an ideological warrior. His approach was to work within the system, leverage his legal training, and push for administrative solutions to structural problems. His reputation at this stage was less that of a firebrand and more that of a capable executive who understood that governance required patient coalition-building.

District (2007–2013)
Deputy Speaker, House of Representatives (2007–2010)

Awards and Recognition

Ten Outstanding Young Men (TOYM) of the Philippines, Public Administration (1974)

Notability

Maguindanaon lawyer, statesman, and peace negotiator; first administrator to organize the provincial government of Maguindanao under PD 341 (1973); five-term congressman; twice Deputy Speaker of the House of Representatives; member of the Philippine government panel that negotiated the 1976 Tripoli Agreement with the MNLF; Secretary of Justice and Secretary of Public Works under President Gloria Macapagal-Arroyo.

Known For

First administrator to organize Maguindanao province under PD 341 (1973); Tripoli Agreement negotiator (1976); founding Director General of OMACC; five-term legislator and twice Deputy Speaker of the House of Representatives; elder statesman of Muslim Mindanao known as "Bapa Sim."

In 1974, he was recognized nationally as one of the Ten Outstanding Young Men (TOYM) of the Philippines for Public Administration — a distinction that marked his emergence not just as a regional politician but as a nationally noticed figure.

ORGANIZING MAGUINDANAO: THE FIRST PROVINCIAL ADMINISTRATOR

The political geography of Mindanao was dramatically redrawn in the early 1970s under the Marcos administration. In November 1973, President Ferdinand E. Marcos Sr. issued Presidential Decree 341, creating three new provinces out of the old undivided Cotabato: Maguindanao, Sultan Kudarat, and North Cotabato. The power to create provinces belonged — and still belongs — exclusively to the President or to Congress, and by 1973, Marcos had padlocked Congress. PD 341 was the act that brought Maguindanao Province into legal existence.

What Datumanong did was take that newly created entity and give it actual functioning shape. As the first governor of Maguindanao from 1973 to 1975, he was the one who organized its administrative structures from the ground up: recruiting staff, establishing offices, defining procedures, and putting operational government services in place for a province that had never existed before. The family has been clear and precise on this point — he did not

create Maguindanao Province, which was Marcos's act under PD 341. What he did was organize it, and that distinction matters. Only a President or Congress can create a province; what a governor can do is build it into something real.

That work was consequential in its own right. No inherited bureaucracy, no established precedents, no tested lines of authority. Datumanong had to construct a provincial government from scratch while managing a constituency simultaneously experiencing the ruptures of the Moro insurgency and the pressures of Martial Law.

He served in that role for two years before moving upward to a regional appointment. But those two years left a structural imprint: the administrative skeleton he assembled became the frame within which all subsequent Maguindanao governance operated. His successor governors inherited the offices, the procedures, and the institutional groundwork that Datumanong had laid.

REGIONAL ADMINISTRATION AND THE 1976 TRIPOLI AGREEMENT

In 1975, Datumanong transitioned from the provincial executive to the regional tier, serving as Regional Commissioner of Region XII — a post he held until 1979. This role oversaw Central Mindanao's multi-province administration and placed him squarely within the orbit of the Marcos government's regional development and pacification strategies.

It was during this period, in 1976, that he participated in one of the most consequential diplomatic events in contemporary Philippine history: the negotiations that produced the Tripoli Agreement.

Signed on December 23, 1976, in Tripoli, Libya, the agreement was the first formal compact between the Philippine government and the Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF), pledging autonomy for thirteen provinces in Mindanao and Sulu. Datumanong served as a member of the Philippine government's negotiating panel in Tripoli, one of the few Muslim Filipino officials involved in crafting what would become the foundational reference document for all subsequent Mindanao peace negotiations.

The following year, in 1977, he served as co-chairperson of the Provisional Government in the Southern Philippines, the short-lived transitional structure envisioned under the Tripoli Agreement's framework. Though the provisional government never fully materialized — Marcos ultimately chose to implement the agreement through two separate autonomous regions rather than the single autonomous structure the MNLF demanded — Datumanong's participation positioned him as one of the key Muslim Filipino architects of the early peace process.

From 1979 to 1984, he served as a regional assemblyman in the Autonomous Regional Government of Western Mindanao and concurrently held the chairmanship of the Lupong Tagapagpaganap ng Pook (LTP), the executive council of Autonomous Region XII, from 1980 to 1984. The LTP itself was a Marcos-created structure — another institution brought into existence by presidential action rather than by the men who ran it. What Datumanong brought to it was the same thing he had brought to Maguindanao Province: the administrative capacity to organize, operationalize, and direct a regional governance structure that was new to the ground. His leadership of the LTP gave him broad executive authority over Region XII's coordination and development functions during a critical period of transition.

THE BATASANG PAMBANSA AND THE OMACC

In 1984, Datumanong reached the apex of his Marcos-era career when he was elected to the Regular Batasang Pambansa representing Maguindanao, while simultaneously being appointed the first Director General of the newly created Office on Muslim Affairs and Cultural Communities (OMACC).

The OMACC was formed on June 30, 1984, through the merger of the Office of Muslim Affairs with the Office of the Presidential Assistant on National Minorities (PANAMIN). It represented the Marcos administration's effort to consolidate management of Muslim and indigenous peoples' affairs under a single government structure.

As OMACC's founding head, Datumanong bore responsibility for directing the agency's programs at a moment when the question of how the Philippine state should relate to its Muslim citizens had never been more contested. The Moro insurgency had not ended; the autonomous regions created under the Tripoli Agreement's flawed implementation remained objects of resentment rather than satisfaction; and the broader Muslim community was navigating profound tensions between traditional religious authority, modernist reform movements, and the political economy of a Martial Law state.

His role at the OMACC — running concurrently with his Batasang Pambansa seat until 1986 — required him to function simultaneously as a lawmaker and a cabinet-level administrator, balancing legislative and executive functions that would become a characteristic feature of his career. He also served on the boards of the Philippine Amanah Bank (1985–1986) and the United Coconut Planters Bank (1986–1992), extending his institutional footprint into the financial sector.

When Corazon Aquino came to power following the EDSA People Power Revolution of February 1986, the OMACC was dissolved and reorganized. On January 30, 1987, President Aquino divided the OMACC into three separate offices: the Office for Muslim Affairs (OMA), the Office for Northern Cultural Communities (ONCC), and the Office for Southern Cultural Communities (OSCC). The dissolution ended Datumanong's ministerial appointment, but it did not remove him from public life. He returned to private practice and board service, waiting for the democratic electoral system to be fully restored.

THREE TERMS IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES (1992–2001)

When the restored Philippine democracy held its first post-Marcos congressional elections in 1987, Datumanong did not immediately enter the fray. His return to elective office came in 1992, when he won the congressional seat for Maguindanao's Second District. He would hold that seat for three consecutive terms, serving from 1992 to 2001 — a stretch of nine years that covered the presidencies of Fidel V. Ramos and Joseph Estrada, and briefly extended into the early Arroyo administration.

As a congressman, his legislative agenda was consistently oriented toward Muslim Mindanao. He pushed for infrastructure investments in the region, championed legislation supporting Muslim education and religious rights, and engaged actively in the debates around the Organic Act that established and later amended the Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (ARMM). He sat on key House committees and used his seniority to advance regional priorities that might otherwise have been overlooked in a House dominated by Luzon-based political networks.

Between 1995 and 1998, during his second term, he served as Deputy Speaker of the House of Representatives — one of the chamber's most senior positions, which gave him agenda-setting authority and placed him among the handful of legislators who shaped what bills reached the floor.

For a Muslim congressman from Maguindanao to hold that position in the mid-1990s was not merely a personal achievement. It was a marker of how far the political representation of Muslim Filipinos had advanced in the national legislature since the dark years of the early insurgency.

He was known within the House as a careful legislator: one who preferred to work through established procedures, build alliances across political lines, and achieve incremental gains rather than dramatic confrontations. Former President Gloria Macapagal-Arroyo, who would later bring him into her cabinet, described him as a man of "uprightness" whose value in any institution came from his reliability and his deep knowledge of Mindanao's political terrain.

CABINET SECRETARY UNDER PRESIDENT ARROYO

In January 2001, following President Arroyo's assumption of the presidency in the wake of EDSA II, Datumanong left the House of Representatives to accept appointment as Secretary of the Department of Public Works and Highways (DPWH). He served in this capacity from January 20, 2001 to January 15, 2003.

The DPWH portfolio was significant for Mindanao: infrastructure development — roads, bridges, flood control systems, public buildings — was among the region's most pressing needs, and having a Maguindanaon Muslim at the helm of the agency responsible for delivering it carried both substantive and symbolic weight.

After his stint at Public Works, Datumanong was moved to an even more visible portfolio. On January 16, 2003, he was appointed Secretary of Justice, a position he held until December 23, 2003. The DOJ secretaryship placed him at the apex of the Philippine legal system's administrative structure, responsible for directing the prosecution service, overseeing the National Bureau of Investigation, managing the Bureau of Corrections, and handling a broad range of politically sensitive legal matters.

His eleven-month tenure as Justice Secretary was brief but consequential. He entered the post during a period of considerable political turbulence: 2003 was the year of the Oakwood Mutiny, when a group of junior military officers seized a Makati hotel and briefly threatened civilian authority. Datumanong's DOJ was tasked with processing the legal aftermath of that crisis, among other pressing matters.

Also during the Arroyo administration, he was appointed to serve on the government's panel for peace negotiations with the Moro Islamic Liberation Front (MILF), an appointment that drew directly on his experience from the 1976 Tripoli negotiations. Government negotiators at the time described him as "very experienced in negotiations" who "knows the problems on the ground and understands the issues very deeply."

RETURN TO CONGRESS: THREE MORE TERMS (2007–2013)

After completing his cabinet service, Datumanong returned to elective politics. In the 2007 congressional elections, he recaptured his seat in the House of Representatives for Maguindanao's Second District, and went on to serve three additional terms until 2013.

This second legislative stint included another term as Deputy Speaker of the House, a position he held from July 23, 2007 to June 30, 2010.

His return to Congress at an age when most politicians would have retired reflected both his personal stamina and the degree to which his constituency continued to regard him as their most effective voice at the national level. In Maguindanao's Second District, Datumanong was not just a political figure — he was an institution, a living embodiment of the district's long engagement with Philippine national governance.

He retired from electoral politics in 2013 at the age of seventy-nine, having completed five terms in the House of Representatives and a career in public service spanning more than five decades. The last years of his life were spent in the dignified elder statesman withdrawal that befits someone who has, by any measure, done everything an ambitious public career can offer.

PASSING AND TRIBUTES

On the evening of February 28, 2017, a telephone call confirmed what many in Mindanao had feared. Simeon Ampatuan Datumanong drew his final breath at the Philippine Heart Center in Quezon City. He was 81 years old.

Within hours, condolences poured in from governors, senators, and former presidents. The Department of Justice flew its flag at half-mast. In Shariff Aguak, the town in Maguindanao where he was born and to which he would be returned for burial, people wept.

That an announcement of a Muslim politician's death could draw such an outpouring of grief from all directions of Philippine society — from Christian senators to Moro governors, from Catholic former presidents to rank-and-file bureaucrats — says something about the kind of life Datumanong led.

Former President Arroyo released a statement describing him as "a strong voice for the equality of our Filipino Muslims" who "exemplified the true Muslim spirit: committed, courageous, sincere, and loyal."

He was buried in Shariff Aguak according to Islamic rites, returned at last to the soil of Maguindanao from which his extraordinary journey had begun.

LEGACY AND HISTORICAL SIGNIFICANCE

Simeon Datumanong's legacy is best understood by placing it within the contested history of Muslim Filipino political integration. For much of the twentieth century, the relationship between the Philippine state and its Muslim citizens was defined by exclusion, dispossession, and armed conflict. The Muslim south was treated as a problem to be managed rather than a community to be genuinely included. Datumanong's career stands as evidence that some Muslim Filipinos found a way to work within that hostile framework to carve out genuine representation and institutional presence at the national level.

His involvement in the 1976 Tripoli Agreement alone would have been sufficient to secure him a place in the historical record. The agreement, despite its ultimately flawed implementation, established the principle that Muslim Mindanao's political status was a matter for formal negotiation between the Philippine government and Moro representatives — a principle that would undergird every subsequent peace effort, from the 1996 Final Peace Agreement with the MNLF to the Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro signed in 2014.

At the regional level, his work as the first governor to organize Maguindanao Province and his subsequent leadership of the Marcos-created LTP Regional Executive Council helped give operational form to Central Mindanao's administrative governance during one of its most chaotic periods. These were acts of institution-building, and their effects outlasted any particular political agenda. The distinction the family rightly insists upon — between creating a structure (which only a president or congress can do) and organizing it into something that actually functions — does not diminish his contribution. If anything, it makes it more precise: Datumanong was not a lawmaker conjuring provinces into existence. He was the administrator who showed up when the decree was signed and made those provinces real.

At the national level, his long House career — five terms, two Deputy Speakerships, and two cabinet appointments — demonstrated that Muslim Filipino politicians could compete effectively in the structures of Philippine national governance without abandoning their identities or their constituencies.

It would be incomplete, however, to present Datumanong's career as entirely without complexity. His political life was inextricably entangled with the Marcos administration, during which he held ministerial and regional executive posts under conditions of Martial Law. His collaboration with the Marcos state was not unique among Mindanao politicians, but it was real, and the historical record requires honest acknowledgment of it.

In his later career, Datumanong was also a respondent in graft cases related to alleged irregularities in the use of his Priority Development Assistance Fund (PDAF), with reports indicating that approximately 3.8 million pesos of his PDAF may have been coursed through a fraudulent non-governmental organization. These charges were never adjudicated during his lifetime, as Philippine law provides that criminal liability is extinguished by death. They remain, however, part of the public record.

What emerges from all of this is the portrait of a politician who was simultaneously a genuine advocate for his community and a pragmatic survivor in a system that demanded accommodation and compromise. These two things are not mutually exclusive — they describe the condition of virtually every successful politician in Philippine history. What distinguished Datumanong was the extraordinary duration of his relevance and the breadth of his institutional footprint.

He carried Muslim Mindanao's voice into rooms it had rarely entered before, and he carried it with the authority of someone who had done the hard, unglamorous work of building institutions from the ground up.

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- Family of Simeon Ampatuan Datumanong, written clarifications submitted to BangsamoroPedia editorial team, June 2026. *(Corrections applied: parents' names and maternal lineage; dates of Board Member and Vice-Governor service; circumstances of assumption of Cotabato governorship; distinction between creation of Maguindanao Province under PD 341 and Datumanong's role in organizing its administrative structures; Marcos-origin of LTP; settler migration policy attribution.)*

EDITORIAL NOTE

On June 2026, a family member of the late Simeon Ampatuan Datumanong submitted factual clarifications to BangsamoroPedia. These corrections have been applied in full to this article. Specific corrections include: (1) the names of his parents, Datu Dundoy Bapa-i Datumanong Giamad and Bai Salama Ampatuan, and the maternal lineage through Datu Alon Ampatuan; (2) revision of his Board Member and Vice-Governor start dates from 1963/1967 to 1962/1966 respectively; (3) clarification that he became Governor of Cotabato through

constitutional succession following Salipada Pendatun's decision not to take his oath, not by direct election to that post; (4) correction of the characterization of his role in Maguindanao Province from "elected first governor" to "first administrator to organize the provincial government," with the province itself created by PD 341 under President Marcos; (5) clarification that the LTP was a Marcos-created structure; and (6) accurate attribution of Mindanao settler migration policy to national legislation and presidential action, not to the actions of local executives. BangsamoroPedia thanks the Datumanong family for their careful attention to the historical record.

CATEGORIES

Editorial Notice: BangsamoroPedia is a curated knowledge archive. Its pages are maintained by the editorial administrator to help ensure historical accuracy. If you would like to suggest corrections, share sources, or contribute information, please message the administrator through the official Facebook page: **Notable Muslim Filipinos**.

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